



## PROGRESS REPORT

# North Africa: progress report, September 2025 – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-04-2 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

*Compiled 2026-09-04 by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository. Sections run from the region's institutions outwards to what funds them. Each opens with a movement ledger comparing the position at the start and end of the period, which runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.*

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION ·  
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Of 12 bodies, instruments and systems on this place's ledger, 10 changed position between 2025-09-01 and 2026-09-04, 1 did not, 1 carry no stated baseline, and 0 are **Not held** at both ends.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 9 sources for this place in the window — 3 in the earlier half (2025-12 to 2026-01), 6 in the later (2026-02 to 2026-08). The two halves are comparable, so the comparison is made over the whole window.

**Movement values.** *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

## Summary of the period

North Africa's ledger opens thin and moves through the Arab League rather than through the AU's continental instruments: two separate AI-ethics charters, a newly staffed AI governance committee, and a conference of civil-status directors, none of them AU-organised. The one running infrastructure programme on the ledger — the France–Tunisia leg of the Medusa submarine cable — reached service during the period, while Ookla's year-one measurement of the region's 5G launches found the aggregate mobile experience worse than before them in three of four markets. PAPSS's North Africa footprint reached four of the region's five states with Algeria's accession, and a stablecoin-based neobank entered the base as the one private-sector system tracked here.

## Institutions and mandates

### Regional collaboration

| BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM                                                  | AT 2025-09-01               | AT 2026-09-04                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | MOVEMENT  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Arab Committee for Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technologies        | Did not exist               | Council approved the creation of an Arab committee for artificial intelligence and emerging technologies, and at the same session adopted the Arab Charter for AI Ethics, described by the Arab League secretariat as a guiding and advisory document resting on ethical principles rather than a binding instrument                                                                                                                     | ADVANCED  |
| Arab conference of nationality and civil-status directors (recommendations) | Did not exist               | Recommended member states expand reliance on digital identity, strengthen legal frameworks protecting personal data in civil-status registers, and share defences against cyber threats aimed at those registers; a model data-protection framework for civil-status registers is to be circulated, and Iraq's proposal for a unified Arab identity was referred to member states for study                                              | ADVANCED  |
| Arab ICT Ministers Council AI working groups (AICTM Executive Bureau)       | Did not exist               | Six working groups chartered under the Arab League's AI governance/digital committee at the 58th AICTM Executive Bureau session; Egypt chairs AI Governance and Quantum Computing, Libya chairs AI Data and Digital Infrastructure, Tunisia chairs AI Innovation — the Governance group's remit includes activating the 2025 Arab Charter for AI Ethics; no framework text, timetable or output yet published from any of the six groups | ADVANCED  |
| Arab Maghreb Union treaty                                                   | In force, dormant (2025-08) | In force since 1 July 1989 with a binding judicial organ, and no summit held since 1994 - a legal frame for regional harmonisation with no active machinery behind it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | NO CHANGE |

Both rows on this section are new this year and both are Arab League tracks rather than AU or REC ones. The AI committee now has its six working groups staffed, three of them chaired by African states, with the Governance group tasked to activate the Arab Charter for AI Ethics — but no framework text or output from any group. The civil-status directors' conference produced recommendations on digital identity and register data protection, with no adoption route yet named.

## Instruments and harmonisation

### Standards

| BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM                       | AT 2025-09-01 | AT 2026-09-04                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | MOVEMENT |
|--------------------------------------------------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| ALECSO Charter on Artificial Intelligence Ethics | Did not exist | Scoped to education, culture and scientific research; asks member states to amend domestic law to implement it and names technological sovereignty among its principles — a second, distinct Arab AI-ethics instrument from the Arab Charter for AI Ethics above | ADVANCED |
| Arab Charter for AI Ethics                       | Did not exist | Non-binding instrument carrying six pillars and about forty principles, including resisting “digital cultural westernisation” (مقاومة التغريب الرقمي), explicitly framed as guidance rather than a substitute for binding regulation                             | ADVANCED |

Two Arab-League AI-ethics instruments sit on the ledger, adopted within weeks of each other in mid-2025 and routinely conflated with one another: the Arab Charter for AI Ethics is a general, non-binding six-pillar instrument covering forty principles, while the ALECSO charter is scoped narrowly to education, culture and scientific research

and asks member states to amend domestic law. Neither carries an enforcement mechanism, and the AI governance committee's own working group tasked with "activating" the former has a chair but no published output as at this report.

## Shared systems and infrastructure

### Connectivity

| BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM                                                    | AT 2025-09-01                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | AT 2026-09-04                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | MOVEMENT          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| <b>Medusa submarine cable system – ViaTunisia (Bizerte–Marseille) segment</b> | Under construction; EU CEF Digital co-financing of €9.6m against a €32m total project budget (the European Commission's own project record, correcting the €10m/~30% figure trade press had carried), project start 1 March 2023 | Bizerte–Marseille segment operational, landing at Bizerte and connecting into Orange's Marseille interconnection hub; part of the wider 8,760km Medusa system, which the landing partner puts at 17 landing points across the northern and southern Mediterranean | ADVANCED          |
| <b>North Africa post-5G mobile network experience (Ookla)</b>                 | Pre-5G-launch mobile network experience baseline (each market's own prior measurement)                                                                                                                                           | Combined 4G+5G median ended below the pre-launch baseline in Egypt, Morocco and Tunisia a year after their 5G launches, with 4G itself down 28% in Morocco and Tunisia; Algeria – whose own 5G licences were only awarded in December 2025 – alone improved       | REGRESSED, MIXED  |
| <b>Algerian 5G rollout</b>                                                    | Not held                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Launched on USD 492 million of licences awarded to the three mobile operators (2025-12)                                                                                                                                                                           | BASELINE NOT HELD |

### Digital Payments and Fintech

| BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM                                     | AT 2025-09-01                      | AT 2026-09-04                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | MOVEMENT |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>Arab Payment Systems Commission (29th ordinary meeting)</b> | Did not exist                      | Regulators set an agenda covering use of biometric data to limit payment fraud, security of the payments digital space and AI in payment-verification services, alongside instant payments and interoperability; no instrument, target date or funding figure is stated                                   | ADVANCED |
| <b>PAPSS membership in North Africa</b>                        | Tunisia, Egypt and Morocco members | Tunisia, Egypt, Morocco and Algeria all members – four of North Africa's five states – within a continental network the operator puts at 18 countries, 150+ commercial banks and 14 switches                                                                                                              | ADVANCED |
| <b>VaulFi stablecoin-powered neobank</b>                       | Did not exist                      | Algerian- and Egyptian-founded startup building a stablecoin-based neobank offering euro-denominated digital accounts across North Africa with cross-border settlement in minutes rather than days; live user accounts at the time of report, with stablecoin-powered cards stated to launch within weeks | ADVANCED |

The one physical infrastructure project on the ledger reached service: the Bizerte–Marseille leg of the Medusa submarine cable, EU co-financed at €9.6m of a €32m budget, went operational in June, landing at Bizerte and joining the wider 17-point Medusa system. Against that single advance, the region's own 5G rollouts measure worse a year on: Ookla's retrospective found the aggregate mobile experience below its pre-launch baseline in three of the four markets that had launched by mid-2025, Algeria's later rollout the exception. Payments infrastructure moved on two

fronts — the Arab Payment Systems Commission opened a fraud- and AI-in-verification agenda with nothing yet adopted, PAPSS's regional footprint reached four of five states, and a stablecoin-based neobank entered the base as the period's one private-sector system.

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## ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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